help of SMAD, the Soviet military government, swept to victory in the 1946 elections for local and regional assemblies held in the Soviet zone.

Predictably, for the SPD, the forced union was disastrous. After enjoying largely equal rights with the KPD, they played hardly any role from 1949 onwards when level representation was abolished, and the communists seized the most influential posts. By the time of East Germany's formal founding in 1949, the SED was a full-fledged communist party – a 'rebranded' KPD.

Prior to this sequence of events, Honecker had settled into the role of chairman of the central youth committee, working from an office at 39-40 Kronenstraße, near Goebbels' old propaganda ministry. 'I could draw on my experience in youth work as a member of the KJVD's Central Committee, as political chief of the KJVD for the Saarland, Ruhr and Berlin Brandenburg Districts,' he recounted. 'The sheer scope and complexity of the task which I had now been entrusted in a completely different situation was only to dawn on me in the following weeks and months.'6 Soon after, he was appointed chairman of the Central Antifascist Youth Committee and six months later, in February 1946, he organised a petition to SMAD requesting permission to form the 'Free German Youth' (FDJ), a 'supra-partisan, united, democratic youth organisation.' The application was approved within two weeks and the Politburo,* then known as the Central Secretariat, appointed thirty-four-year-old Erich Honecker as FDJ chairman.7 He took credit for uniting former members of the KJVD, Socialist Workers' Youth, members of the Protestant and Catholic youth federations 'in other words, young people from all classes and sections of society united in the Free German Youth'.

With Ulbricht looking over his shoulder, the 'Free German Youth' was unveiled at the State Theatre on 10 March 1946. The more astute observers wrinkled their noses, recognising that although 'unity and non-partisanship' were invoked from the start, the FDJ – like the SED – would develop as an arm of the communists. 'Everybody understood that,' said Ed Stuhler, biographer of Margot Feist, a young FDJ functionary. 'That was Ulbricht's ultimate intention. It was a charade that just played out,'8 (for example, while the key areas of FDJ finance and public relations fell into communist